The Queen Who Had to Be Seen: Elizabeth II, Image and Power

Student sheet · Terminale, general and technological pathway · tronc commun: B2 · spécialité LLCER anglais: towards C1 by the end of Terminale, with C1 tasks.

Eight lessons of 55 minutes, timed for 52 minutes, plus a mid-sequence assessment, a written test and a final task. Official page: https://itineraires-destinations.fr/portrait-of-a-queen/

Key question of the sequence: How does a Queen who reigns but does not rule exercise power through her image?

Write on this sheet, or in your notebook. Answer keys and marking grids are always visible on the official pages. Make your own bristol flashcards: there is no ready-made deck. Copyrighted portraits (Annigoni, Freud, Beaton) and stills from *The Crown* are not reproduced: use the official links on the site.

Lesson 1. Dignified power

Key question. How does a Queen who reigns but does not rule exercise power through her image?

You already know, from The King Reigns and Who Rules Britain? if you have studied them: dignified and efficient power, reign or rule, the three rights of the sovereign. We do not repeat those exercises here.

Recap

1. In one sentence, what is the difference between reigning and ruling?
2. Which part of the constitution, in Bagehot's vocabulary, wins reverence?
3. Name one official image of a monarch that you have already seen in another lesson.

Steps 1 and 2, applied to de László, 1933

Identify (who, when, for whom, where). Describe (format, pose, gaze, light, background).

Speaking

"A face on a stamp is a political act." Agree or disagree. Write one concession and your answer.

Exit ticket and homework

Definition of dignified power through image:

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Homework: official photograph (give the link, do not copy the picture). Steps 1 and 2:

Lesson 2. Gloriana: the first Elizabeth’s mask

Key question. How does a royal portrait construct a timeless, almost divine image? The Armada Portrait is reserved for the mid-sequence test: do not analyse its two windows here.

Five-step notes on the Ditchley Portrait

1. Identify
2. Describe
3. Read the symbols (globe, dress, weather)
4. Interpret (mask of youth)
5. Reception (what this official image was for)

Writing, 150 words

How does the Ditchley Portrait construct a timeless, almost divine image of the Queen?

Exit ticket and homework

What is the mask of youth? One symbol in the Ditchley Portrait:

Homework: one widely shared image of Elizabeth II in old age (give the link). Controlled or not? 8 to 10 lines.

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Lesson 3. A vow: Cape Town, 21 April 1947

Key question. Was the vow a personal promise, or the voice of an institution? Official text: https://www.royal.uk/21st-birthday-speech-21-april-1947

Rhetoric

Copy the vow accurately, with quotation marks. Name the performative verb, the antithesis, and the phrase “imperial family”.

How would this speech have sounded in India or Kenya in 1947?

Homework, 120 words

Is a promise made at 21 a personal choice or a role imposed by birth? Quote the speech and use one concession.

Lesson 4. Crowned on camera, 2 June 1953

Key question. Did television make the monarchy stronger, or more fragile? Beaton’s coronation portraits are still in copyright: use the official Royal Collection page, do not copy the picture. *The Crown* is not a source for this lesson.

What was shown, and what was hidden (the anointing)?

Debate notes (one argument, one concession):

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Homework: revise the method, the Ditchley key points and the 1947 quotation. Do not prepare a full analysis of the Armada Portrait.

Mid-sequence assessment (after lesson 4)

Written test of 55 minutes, timed for 52 minutes, /20. You may use your method notes. You may not use a phone or the internet.

Part A · Unseen portrait (/10)

Document: the Armada Portrait of Elizabeth I (about 1588), projected in class and on the official page.

1. Describe the composition and the attributes of power. (3)
2. Explain what the two windows in the background represent. (2)
3. What image of the Queen is constructed? Use two adjectives from the method. (3)
4. Compare with the Ditchley Portrait in two sentences. (2)

Part B · Short argument (/10)

150 to 180 words: “Elizabeth II’s vow of 1947 was a political act, not a personal one.” Quote the speech accurately.

Self-correction (before I hand in)

I check that…	Yes	Partly	No
I described the portrait in steps (format, pose, attributes, background).			
I interpreted the two windows and the symbols.			

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My argument has a clear position in the first sentence.			
I quoted the 1947 speech correctly, with quotation marks.			
I used at least one concession (Admittedly…, nevertheless…).			
I checked verbs (tense, -s at the third person) and spelling.			

My main strength: _____ · What I must improve next time: _____

Lesson 5. Annigoni 1955, Freud 2001

Key question. Does a royal portrait owe the public the truth, or flattery? The two paintings are still in copyright and are not reproduced. Official pages: Fishmongers' Hall (Annigoni); Royal Collection Trust, RCIN 407895 (Freud).

Contrast of format and gaze:

Debate: one concession, then a rebuttal.

Homework: 200-word review of one portrait for an art magazine (give the official link, do not copy the picture). Draft here if you wish:

Lesson 6. Annus horribilis, 24 November 1992

Official text: https://www.royal.uk/annus-horribilis-speech

Copy the "Annus Horribilis" sentence accurately. What is litotes, and why quote a correspondent?

Homework: the passage on criticism of institutions (short accurate quotation) and 8 lines: does it confirm or qualify the idea that royalty lives on mystery?

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Lesson 7. 1997 and 2020: speaking to the nation

Official texts: https://www.royal.uk/queens-message-following-death-diana-princess-wales and https://www.royal.uk/queens-broadcast-uk-and-commonwealth

1997: what does “Queen and grandmother” do that “Queen” alone would not do?

2020: name the device in the ending and its effect. Why recall the Second World War?

Mediation in French, 100 words

For a French newspaper: why were these two short speeches so important? Write in French, for a French reader; do not translate the speeches word for word.

Lesson 8. *The Crown*: fiction, history and the right to invent

The Crown is studied as fiction, compared with the historical record. It is not a source for what happened. No film stills are reproduced. Official trailer: https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=JWtnJjn6ng0

One example of invention or compression (Aberfan, or the 1997 broadcast), and why it matters:

Should drama about living people carry a warning? One argument, one concession:

Prepare the final task

Format chosen: gallery talk / op-ed / commission letter. Three sources (portrait, speech, other):

The objection I will answer:

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Summative written test

2 hours, /20, coefficient 2. Document: the Queen's first televised Christmas broadcast, 1957 (official page: https://www.royal.uk/christmas-broadcast-1957). The speech is not copied in full here. Work from the official text or from the print-out given in class.

1. Comprehension (/6). What does the Queen say about television and about her own role? Find two expressions showing her distance and two showing closeness.
2. Analysis (/4). Identify two rhetorical devices and explain their effect.
3. Mediation in French (/4), 100 words, for a French history class, on why this broadcast marked a turning point. Write in French; do not translate the speech word for word.
4. Essay (/6), 250 to 300 words: "The monarchy survived because it learnt to be seen." Discuss with examples from the sequence.

Use the lined paper given in class, or your notebook, for the full answers. Self-correction before you hand in:

I check that…	Yes	Partly	No
I answered every question about the 1957 broadcast.			
My mediation is in French, adapted to a French history class, and is not a translation.			
My essay has an introduction with the question, two parts and a conclusion.			
I used two examples from the sequence (a portrait, a speech, *The Crown*).			
I used vocabulary such as dignified, iconic, idealised, legitimacy.			
I wrote between 250 and 300 words for the essay.			

My main strength: _____ · What I must improve next time: _____

Final task: The image and the Crown

/20, coefficient 2. Choose one task. Use at least three sources from the sequence (one portrait, one speech, one other) and answer one objection. Copyrighted works are presented from official pages, not copied into a handout.

- **Gallery talk** (5 minutes + 3 minutes of questions). You are a curator presenting a new exhibition, "The Queen Who Had to Be Seen", to journalists.
- **Op-ed** (350 to 400 words). "*The Crown* has done more harm than good to the monarchy." Argue for or against.
- **Commission letter** (C1, 300 words + a 2-minute oral defence). You are King Charles III's adviser. Write to a painter to commission an official portrait: what should it show, and why?

I check that…	Yes	Partly	No
I chose one format and respected its length or time.			
I used three sources (portrait, speech, other) from the sequence.			

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I answered one objection.			
I used at least two complex structures (inversion, conditional, passive).			
For the gallery talk: I rehearsed and can speak without reading.			
For the op-ed or letter: I reread for accuracy and register.			

My main strength: _____ · What I must improve next time: _____

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